



Motivation letter: structure, template and the mistakes that sink it

A ready skeleton with a note on what each paragraph has to do

academgo.com · Warsaw, ul. Złota 7/28

A motivation letter matters where a person decides, not a score calculator: master's programmes, scholarships and competitive places at private universities. It will not rescue weak grades, but between two similar applicants it decides who gets the offer.

Where it is actually required

What you apply for	Is a letter needed
Bachelor's at a private university, by school certificate	usually not
Master's	almost always: letter, CV and one or two references
MBA (Dubai branch campuses)	letter, CV and proof of work experience, usually from three years
Government scholarships (Türkiye Bursları, Stipendium Hungaricum)	yes, and it carries much of the decision
Competitive programmes at private universities	yes, sometimes as an essay of 300–500 words

On competitive scholarships the letter weighs a lot: one Turkish programme receives about 1,500 applications for 83 places, and the essay is part of how they choose.

Language and length

Write in the language of the programme — nearly always English. One page, 400–600 words, four or five paragraphs. If the university sets a limit — 500 words, two pages — the limit beats any advice here.

The skeleton

Copy it and fill it in. The notes say what each paragraph must do.

> **Paragraph 1 — who you are and what you are applying for.** No run-up. > > *I am applying for the MSc in Data Science at [University]. I hold a bachelor's degree in [field] from [university], graduated in [year] with a GPA of [X].*

> **Paragraph 2 — why this programme.** Name two or three specific courses, a lab, a professor or a feature of the curriculum. This paragraph proves you read the programme page instead of mailing one letter to twenty universities. > > *The programme's focus on [course name] and [course name] matches what I want to work on: [short, concrete goal].*

> **Paragraph 3 — what you have behind you.** Studies, work, projects, volunteering. Every example ends in a result: what you did, what came out of it, the numbers. > > *During my internship at [company] I built [what] and [result: number, effect]. I also [project / volunteering] — this is where I learned [skill relevant to the programme].*

> **Paragraph 4 — why this country and what comes next.** An honest three-to-five-year plan. Admissions care that you know where you are going after graduation. > > *After graduation I plan to [concrete plan]. A degree from [country] gives me [specific reason: accreditation, language, industry, link to your home market].*

> **Paragraph 5 — a short close.** One or two sentences. No "I hope for a positive decision". > > *I would be glad to contribute to [programme / lab / student community] and to bring [what you bring].*

What makes a letter stronger

- **Specifics instead of adjectives.** Not "I am responsible and motivated", but "I ran 14 projects in two years and none slipped its deadline".
 - **Numbers.** People in the team, how much a metric grew, hours of practice.
 - **A link to the programme.** Every paragraph should explain why you fit this programme.
 - **Your own story.** A concrete reason for choosing the field is remembered; general words about prestigious education are not.
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Seven mistakes that make a letter useless

- **One letter for every university.** Admissions spot it instantly: no programme name, no course names.
- **Retelling your CV.** The letter explains the choice; it does not duplicate the résumé.

- **Compliments to the country and the university.** "Your university is world-renowned" adds nothing.
 - **Promises instead of facts.** "I will learn the language quickly" is weaker than "I scored IELTS 6.5 in May".
 - **Exaggeration.** Experience and achievements are checked against documents; a mismatch is grounds for rejection.
 - **Length.** Two pages instead of one get skimmed.
 - **Wrong names.** The wrong programme or university name in the letter is a common and expensive typo.
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Checklist before you send

- The programme and university names match the website exactly.
 - You are inside the word or page limit.
 - Every paragraph carries at least one concrete fact or number.
 - No sentence runs past 25 words.
 - The text has been checked by a native speaker, or at least by a grammar checker.
 - The file is a PDF named Surname_Name_Motivation_Letter.pdf.
 - For scholarships: the letter answers "why you", not "why this country".
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We will review your letter. Send the draft and the programme link — we will tell you what to cut, what to add and where the wording works against you. The first consultation is free. AcademGo office: Warsaw, ul. Żłota 7/28.

Send us your draft and the programme link — we will go through it paragraph by paragraph

AcademGo — study abroad consultancy. All figures come from official university and government sources; check the year of the price list before you pay.